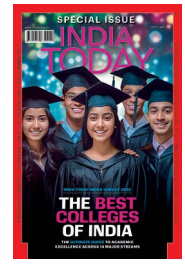
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

A degree from an international university has long been an ambition of the Indian student. Once, however, it was only a privilege of the few. Now, an unprecedented number of young Indians, from the big cities and small towns alike, are headed to foreign universities for higher studies. Last summer saw 750,365 new students take that plane—the highest in six years, and 161,642 more than in 2019. An online platform estimated the total number of students studying abroad then at 1.32 million, up from 1.14 million in 2021. Projections for 2024 take that up to 1.8 million. Let that sink in. There are some 50 countries with total populations below the number of young Indians studying abroad.

That upward graph isn't surprising, for it has been climbing consistently. As the much-televised reverse exodus during the initial days of the Ukraine war told even those who had not been paying attention, Indian students are not sailing only to the familiar ports of call—the American universities that became the staple in the Eighties, the older British ones or extensions of the Anglosphere, like Canada or Australia. They now stream out to even remote East European nations and other surprising places on the world map. When Covid struck, much to our surprise, we learnt that nearly 23,000 Indians were studying in China, and 700 of them in Wuhan, the epicentre of the outbreak, as they began returning home at the start of 2020.

Back on US campuses, Indian students are set to overtake Chinese ones, so far the dominant cohort among foreign students. The OpenDoors report by the US-based Institute of International Education notes how the number of Indian students studying in the US shot up by 18.9 per cent—from 167,582 to 199,982—between 2020-21 and 2021-22, while those from China saw a decline of 8.6 per cent—from 317,299 to 290,086. Likewise, an immigration statistics report released by the UK in 2022 showed that more visas—127,731—were issued to Indian students compared to the 116,476 given to Chinese students.



July 3, 2023

A number of factors have converged to create this mini-tsunami of Indian students in foreign universities. Covid was an initial reason. In that first flush of the pandemic, a giant grey fog of uncertainty covered everything in sight. Nations and cities clanged their entry gates shut. The very idea of travel evoked fear and trembling, and global mobility hit a long pause. None was affected more than the young, for whom it seemed like a futureless chasm. As the nightmare ended, visas started getting stamped again and boarding gates brimmed over with youthful voyagers, and the turnstiles of the future, it seemed, were turning once more.

Three years on, it appears to be more than just a resumption of business as normal after a pause. India's higher education landscape has always been marked by an endemic poverty of choices, both quantitative and qualitative. There's numerical scarcity, to begin with. Last year, for some 1.4 million students who came out of school, central universities offered just 200,000 seats, besides the scant intake in professional courses. That gap is too much to be filled by private colleges, mushrooming though they may be. To top that were the ludicrous cutoff percentages for entry into any decent college.

To solve the problem, the government introduced CUET, a Common University Entrance Test for admission to central universities, which came into play just last year. This flipped the rules of the competitive game in India. It addressed an existing distortion—the unreal cutoffs for admission that loomed like a fearsome ogre guarding college gates. Pure demand-based inflation, it placed enormous stakes on the Class 12 board results. CUET, on the other hand, is designed to judge students for their conceptual mastery rather than mere rote memory. But while diminishing the high premium on the Class 12 boards, it has in effect only replaced it with another exam. As a counsellor tells INDIA TODAY, India is "going the test way" while "the world is moving towards the test optional method". The little starting trouble CUET had last year only added to the cloud of uncertainty.

More than anything, however, foreign universities offer a different kind of richness in educational experience that students do not seem to be finding in their own country. The Indian education system has failed to rise above textbook and classroom learning, with a syllabus that is out of sync with Gen Z's interests and ambitions. So, when Devanshi Sood, 18, wanted to pursue her primary interest, environment technology, she found it was simply not available as a subject in India. America offered not just an entry into it, but also a bustling market for it afterward in a world seized of climate change issues. She is now headed for a four-year bachelor's in Computational Media at the Georgia Institute of Technology, US. "This degree will offer me room to experiment," she says. "I like science and computers... but also literature and political science."

Flexible curriculums, tremendous research opportunities, world-class faculty and facilities... a wealth of reasons is fuelling the new exodus of Indian students to foreign shores. "The universities and education abroad let students express themselves, be critical, offer useful and practical knowledge," says Dinesh Singh, the former vice-chancellor of Delhi University and the current chancellor of KR Mangalam University in Gurugram.

Studying in a different cultural environment and interacting with people of other nationalities is also an education in itself, introducing students to new perspectives, ideas and ways of life, thus broadening their horizons. Foreign universities, too, are welcoming Indian students for this reason, for the diversity they bring to their classrooms, and the fillip their stay provides to the host nation's economy. They are thus working hard to demystify the application processes, devise student-friendly visa policies and offer attractive scholarships, which can significantly reduce tuition and living expenses for students.

Indian parents, too, now aspire the best for their children's education. Rising disposable incomes help fund their ambitions for their offspring; collateral-free loans have also made foreign education affordable for Indian students. Canada, for instance, has become a favoured destination for its affordable quality education. If the annual cost of a four-year undergraduate degree in the US works out to $40,000-$55,000 (Rs 33 lakh-Rs 45 lakh), it is CAD 20,000-CAD 35,000 (Rs 12.4 lakh-Rs 21.7 lakh) in Canada.

However, it is not just the Anglophone countries that students are flocking to, mainly because of the large Indian diaspora in the US, UK, Canada and Australia, but also countries like Italy, France and Germany, not to mention the Southeast Asian countries. But whatever the direction of their journey, it ends at a familiar destination—the environs of a foreign university. This exodus of students should be a warning sign to our Desi rote learning educational system to mend its ways. With all its fine academic talent, India has the potential to become one of the great centres of learning in the world given the right government policies and funding. No developing country has advanced without a well-educated population. Meanwhile, we can only wish our children bon voyage and hope they return.



(Aroon Purie)